to apply on its old demand: it has issued an ultimatum for the entire Nishad continuum to be taken out of the Other Backward Classes (OBC) bracket and be reclassified in the Scheduled Caste (SC) list.

The Nishads are a cluster of castes traditionally tied to fishing, fish-rearing, boating and allied work. Population estimates vary in the 5-9 per cent range, but their footprint is spread across and is especially strong over the denser hydrological map of the east. Nishad leaders claim a hold over 80 seats out of UP's 403, and influence in over 160 assembly seats.

The BJP was at the river early. Before the 2019 Lok Sabha election, it wooed the NP—hitherto an independent force in eastern UP—into the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Praveen Nishad, son of party chief Sanjay Nishad, joined the BJP and won Sant Kabir Nagar. Things looked pat: the BJP had a Nishad face, and it fitted neatly into its larger strategy of consolidating non-Yadav OBC communities in Purvanchal.

Before the 2022 election, the NP complained the BJP had not fulfilled its promise on quotas. But the alliance survived; Sanjay Nishad joined the Yogi Adityanath cabinet, albeit as a tactical malcontent. He has raked up the issue again, threatening to give up his ministerial position if the quota is not granted. For the BJP, conceding the demand is tricky, but evasion would hand an edge to the Opposition. The 2024 Lok Sabha polls offered a reminder that its compact with the Nishads can't always guarantee votes. In Sant Kabir Nagar, Praveen Nishad lost to SP's Laxmikant, aka Pappu Nishad, by 92,170 votes. Laxmikant got 45.7 per cent of the total votes.

READY WITH A HOOK

That fluidity is what the Opposition hopes to exploit. The SP has a natural opening through its PDA—i.e. *Pichhda* or backward, Dalit and *Alpsankhyak* or minority—strategy: the Nishads are a perfect target in its bid to expand beyond its old Yadav base, and it can invoke past association with figures such as Phoolan Devi. The power of this equation was demonstrated in the 2018 Gorakhpur LS bypoll: Praveen, then backed by the SP, had defeated the BJP in a seat vacated by none other than Yogi. Rai's presence at the Ayodhya gathering shows the Congress, too, is fishing at the river—its pro-quota narrative dovetails well into the emerging scenario.

Another player to watch is Bihar's Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP) chief Mukesh Sahani, who has begun campaigning in UP around the quota issue. He, too, has issued a deadline and warns that Nishads would abjure their BJP loyalties if not heeded. The VIP's political model harks back to the NP's original one: a riverine community as an independent bargaining force. That sharpens the challenge for Sanjay Nishad as well. It's a bit of a whirlpool. ■

Takeaways

- **A battle is on for the Nishad vote between BJP, SP-Cong. Nishad Party ups its ante on quota**
- **Barring a few sub-castes, the Nishads are largely slotted as OBC in UP. They want SC listing**
- **BJP aims to hold on to its tie-up with NP; SP invokes past association with Phoolan**

▶ RAJASTHAN

Cows That Live Only On Paper

CAG finds huge anomalies in Rajasthan's cow shelter programme—non-existent cattle may have munched off crores of public money

By **Rohit Parihar**

IN THE 1995 GHETTO DRAMA *LA HAINE*, A CHARACTER hallucinates about a cow wandering across a Parisian suburb. What's surreal in France is, of course, utterly ordinary in India—but it seems phantom cows do exist here. If the grey areas flagged by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) turn out to be maximally black, as many as 131,000 cows may have existed only on Rajasthan's official documents. What's more, in the year ended March 2024, they even devoured Rs 57.36 crore in excess grants.

The scheme itself is simple and humane: the state's animal husbandry department, specifically the cow-specific wing called the 'Gopalan Directorate', pays registered *gaushala*s that take in,



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

FECKLESS MATADORS A cow shelter in Sanchore, Rajasthan